

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Manufacturing English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For plant managers, production supervisors, quality engineers, maintenance teams, industrial engineers, safety leads, supply planners, and manufacturing-adjacent professionals.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

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Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

- 01 Morning tier meeting
- 02 Changeover improvement
- 03 Scrap versus rework
- 04 Recurring dimensional defect
- 05 Preventive maintenance window
- 06 A safety concern on the line
- 07 Incoming material discrepancy
- 08 Shift handover

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Morning tier meeting

The packaging line has missed its hourly production target.

Roles: Production supervisor / Line leader / Maintenance technician

Production supervisor: We're 160 units behind plan. Where are we losing time?

Line leader: At the case sealer. We've had four short stops since startup.

Maintenance technician: Is it the same fault code each time?

Line leader: Yes, the infeed sensor. Operators logged each stop on the downtime sheet.

Production supervisor: Can we recover the schedule without adding a second shift?

Maintenance technician: I need to inspect the sensor under the approved isolation procedure before estimating downtime.

Line leader: I'll separate the affected cases and update the hour-by-hour board.

Production supervisor: Good. Maintenance owns the fault check; I'll revise the production plan after your assessment.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We're 160 units behind plan. Where are we losing time?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Changeover improvement

A production team reviews a lengthy product changeover.

Roles: Continuous improvement engineer / Setup technician

Continuous improvement engineer: The changeover took 52 minutes. Which steps required the machine to be stopped?

Setup technician: Tooling adjustment and first-piece approval. We also spent ten minutes finding the change parts.

Continuous improvement engineer: Could we stage those parts before shutdown?

Setup technician: Yes, but the kit needs a check sheet. Two guides look almost identical.

Continuous improvement engineer: Let's trial a labeled changeover cart on the next run.

Setup technician: Keep the first-piece inspection in the sequence. That's not time we can simply remove.

Continuous improvement engineer: Agreed. We'll measure searching time separately from adjustment and inspection.

Setup technician: I'll prepare the kit and record anything missing before the trial.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The changeover took 52 minutes. Which steps required the machine to be stopped?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Scrap versus rework

Quality and production review scratched housings.

Roles: Quality engineer / Production supervisor

Quality engineer: The inspection report shows 24 scratched housings. Are all 24 scrap?

Production supervisor: Not yet. Six look suitable for rework, but we haven't received a disposition.

Quality engineer: Keep the entire group identified and segregated until that review is complete.

Production supervisor: Can we count the six toward today's good output?

Quality engineer: Only after approved rework and acceptance. They aren't conforming units yet.

Production supervisor: Understood. I'll report 24 on hold, with six proposed for rework.

Quality engineer: I'll check the acceptance criteria and document the disposition.

Production supervisor: Send the approved instructions to the line leader before we start.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The inspection report shows 24 scratched housings. Are all 24 scrap?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Recurring dimensional defect

A team investigates an out-of-tolerance bore.

Roles: Quality engineer / Process engineer

Quality engineer: The bore diameter is drifting toward the upper limit again.

Process engineer: Tool wear is my leading hypothesis, but the gauge readings need checking.

Quality engineer: The operator says the gauge was dropped yesterday.

Process engineer: Then let's verify the measurement system before changing the offset.

Quality engineer: What happens to the parts produced since the last accepted check?

Process engineer: We'll identify that interval and ask quality to define containment.

Quality engineer: I'll arrange the gauge check and preserve the inspection records.

Process engineer: I'll compare tool life and machine history. We shouldn't close the corrective action on a guess.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "What happens to the parts produced since the last accepted check?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Preventive maintenance window

Maintenance and planning negotiate access to a bottleneck machine.

Roles: Maintenance planner / Production planner

Maintenance planner: The press is due for preventive maintenance this week. I need a four-hour window.

Production planner: Thursday's schedule is full. Could we move it into next month?

Maintenance planner: I can't approve an extension. The reliability engineer needs to assess that request.

Production planner: What about Friday after the priority order?

Maintenance planner: That could work if the spare seals arrive and we have the right technician.

Production planner: I'll reserve a provisional slot and flag the dependency on parts.

Maintenance planner: I'll confirm parts availability by tomorrow's planning meeting.

Production planner: Then we'll release the revised schedule once the maintenance window is confirmed.

Notice the professional language

preventive maintenance - Planned work intended to reduce failures and maintain equipment condition.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

A safety concern on the line

An operator reports a damaged guard before startup.

Roles: Machine operator / Shift supervisor

Machine operator: The guard latch isn't engaging. I haven't started the machine.

Shift supervisor: Thanks for stopping. Keep it out of service while we get maintenance involved.

Machine operator: The previous shift said it sometimes catches on the second attempt.

Shift supervisor: That doesn't establish that it's safe. We'll follow the equipment isolation and reporting procedure.

Machine operator: Should I log it as a breakdown or a safety concern?

Shift supervisor: Record the guard defect and the actual condition; I'll make sure both teams receive it.

Machine operator: I'll hand the job sheet to the maintenance lead.

Shift supervisor: I'll reassign the work and confirm who authorizes a return to service.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Should I log it as a breakdown or a safety concern?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Incoming material discrepancy

Receiving finds different material identification on a delivery.

Roles: Receiving inspector / Supplier quality engineer

Receiving inspector: The purchase order specifies grade 304, but these labels say 316.

Supplier quality engineer: Does the certificate of analysis match the labels or the order?

Receiving inspector: The certificate says 316. The delivery note says 304.

Supplier quality engineer: Put the delivery on hold. We need traceability back to the supplier's batch.

Receiving inspector: Production is asking whether the higher grade is automatically acceptable.

Supplier quality engineer: A different grade needs engineering review; we can't substitute it ourselves.

Receiving inspector: I'll photograph the labels and send the batch numbers.

Supplier quality engineer: I'll raise the supplier discrepancy and request a corrected explanation and documents.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Does the certificate of analysis match the labels or the order?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Shift handover

The incoming supervisor takes over a partly completed order.

Roles: Outgoing supervisor / Incoming supervisor

Outgoing supervisor: Order 418 is running, but pallet seven is on quality hold.

Incoming supervisor: What's the reason, and which units are affected?

Outgoing supervisor: A missing inspection entry. The hold tag lists serial numbers 601 through 624.

Incoming supervisor: Have those units been moved to the hold area?

Outgoing supervisor: Yes. Quality has the record; no disposition yet.

Incoming supervisor: So the remaining pallets can follow the normal release process, but pallet seven stays held.

Outgoing supervisor: Correct. The line also needs new labels before the next order.

Incoming supervisor: I'll follow up with quality and verify the label change at setup.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "What's the reason, and which units are affected?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Production Flow and Daily Management

SHARED CASE

A production line made 840 units against a 1,000-unit target. The log records 40 minutes of downtime; its cause is still being checked.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

Output was 160 units below target, and the log shows 40 minutes of downtime. We have not confirmed the cause. I'll include the downtime review in the next production update.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Lean, Waste, and Continuous Improvement

SHARED CASE

A team observes repeated waiting for shared tools during a kaizen event. A supervisor blames slow operators.

Role A | Responding professional

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Useful expressions

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The observed delay occurs while people wait for shared tools. Let's examine tool availability and layout before attributing the issue to individual speed. Could we test a revised arrangement?

Second round

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Defects, Scrap, and Rework

SHARED CASE

A quality report combines scrapped units with units awaiting rework. The manager needs to understand the different consequences.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Scrap and rework are different outcomes. Scrapped units will not return to the process as usable product; rework attempts to make units conform. I'll report their quantities separately.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Root Cause and Corrective Action

SHARED CASE

A defect appears after a supplier change, but several process settings also changed. A team member names the supplier as the root cause.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The timing makes the supplier change worth examining, but other settings changed too. It is a hypothesis, not an established root cause. Let's compare the evidence before closing the investigation.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Maintenance, Reliability, and Changeover

SHARED CASE

A planned maintenance window conflicts with a rush order. The maintenance team needs to explain the available options to the decision maker.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Useful expressions

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Cover this until after your first attempt

The rush order and maintenance window compete for the same equipment. Could we review the approved options, expected production impact, and reliability concerns together before changing the plan?

Second round

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

EHS and Safety Communication

SHARED CASE

During a safety exercise, a learner notices an unclear equipment-isolation instruction. The local approved procedure must govern the work.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

I need clarification of this instruction before the task proceeds. Please involve the authorized person and use the approved safety procedure. I will point out exactly which instruction is unclear.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Supplier Quality and Incoming Materials

SHARED CASE

An incoming inspection report cites a dimension without identifying the drawing revision. The supplier used a different revision.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Which drawing revision applies to this delivery? Let's record both references and ask the responsible quality team to resolve the discrepancy before we describe the material as conforming.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Shift Handoffs and Escalation

SHARED CASE

The outgoing shift has completed six of eight checks. Two checks remain open, with records attached and a named incoming supervisor.

Role A | Responding professional

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Useful expressions

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Cover this until after your first attempt

Six checks are complete; two remain open. The records show what has been checked and what is pending. Please confirm that the incoming supervisor has accepted the follow-up tasks.

Second round

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.